Chapter 7

Stormy Seas

Protracted negotiations for a ceasefire in Jammu and Kashmir between generals Bucher and Gracey gained currency with the Templer Report. The fear of a collapse in the Pakistan Army intensified the pressure on the need for the ceasefire. Their dream of a complete takeover of the state through proxy forces in Pakistan now lay in tatters. The ceasefire brokered by the two British generals was agreed to by both the countries and finally came into effect on 1 January 1949. The terms of the ceasefire, as laid out in a UN resolution of 13 August 1948, were adopted by the UN on 5 January 1949. This required Pakistan to withdraw all its forces from the entire state including the Poonch-Muzaffarabad belt and the Gilgit Agency while allowing India to maintain minimal military strength in the state, so as to preserve law and order. On full compliance of these conditions, a plebiscite was to be held to determine the future of the state.

To Pakistan, the plebiscite and these conditions were a shattering blow. This had been a considerable gamble for the British and the Pakistanis; had Pakistan lost, then not only would Azad Kashmir have disappeared into Sheikh Abdullah's empire, but it was inevitable that India would have done everything in its power to displace Pakistan from the Gilgit Agency and to regain control over the entire northern frontier. Both sides, however, at the outset, converged on one point of great importance—the state of Jammu and Kashmir would be treated as a whole; there was no question of holding